EVOLUTIONARY ANTHROPOLOGY

Our Tribal Future

How to Channel Our Foundational Human Instincts into a Force for Good

David R. Samson · 2023

An evolutionary anthropologist argues that tribalism is a core human drive we can't switch off, and that we can point it toward belonging and trust instead of division. Winner of the 2023 Balsillie Prize for Public Policy.[1,2,3]

WHY READ IT

- A big-picture view of why we form groups at all[4,5]
- Practical ideas for building real community[4]
- A thought-provoking, sometimes debated argument[6]

GET THE BOOK



Our Tribal Future by David R. Samson

St. Martin's Press, 2023. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

The book ↗ David R. Samson (University of Toronto) ↗

A free guide inspired by *Our Tribal Future* by David R. Samson. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Belonging is an instinct

Samson calls it the Tribe Drive: an evolved urge to belong to groups that helped our ancestors survive. We can't remove it, he argues, but we can choose where it goes, into small, real, trusting groups, or into abstract camps that feed division.[1,4,5]

THREE LESSONS

1 **The trust paradox**

Our minds were built for kin and friends, yet we cooperate with millions of strangers. Shared symbols and rituals make that trust possible.[4]

2 **We're under-ritualized**

Modern life has lost many of the rituals that once bound groups together.[4]

3 **Beliefs as badges**

Samson argues that some beliefs work as signals of loyalty to a group, which is why facts alone rarely change minds.[4,6]

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THE FRAMEWORK

The Tribe Drive, redirected[4,5]

Samson's argument in four steps. Some of his proposals are debated by other scholars.[4,6]

1 The Tribe Drive

Belonging is basic

We evolved to belong to nested groups, from family to band to tribe.[1,6]

Try: Notice which groups you say "we" about.

2 Campcrafting

Small groups, close together

Invest in face-to-face groups like the hunter-gatherer camp of 20 to 30 people.[4,6]

Try: Start with a weekly meal.[4]

3 Ritual

The currency of trust

Rituals and symbols help strangers trust each other.[4]

Try: Give a group a name or an opening ritual.

4 Metabelief

A vaccine for tribalism

Beliefs that update with evidence, toward a shared identity he calls Team Human.[4,5]

Try: Ask what evidence would change your mind.

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

Map your tribes

Inspired by the author's interview on The Hub.[5]

1. List the groups you're proud to belong to.
2. Mark each as face-to-face or abstract.
3. Move time and energy toward the face-to-face ones.

Campcraft a circle

Applying the book's campcrafting and ritual ideas.[4]

1. Invite 4 to 10 people to a recurring gathering.
2. Give it a name or a simple ritual.
3. Hold it for eight weeks, then decide together whether to continue.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it eight weeks

1. Map your tribes.
2. Choose one face-to-face group to invest in.
3. Add one ritual to it.
4. Practise metabelief: write down a belief and what would change your mind.

REFLECT

Which of your tribes would show up for you in a hard week?

Where is your instinct to belong being used by someone else's algorithm?

Try it in Sedi: Put your circle on Timely as a recurring event, and keep ritual ideas in Brainly.

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READ THE BOOK

🔥 Our Tribal Future

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David R. Samson (University of Toronto): utm.utoronto.ca/shel/node/2

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This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with David R. Samson or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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